

Do things that don't scale

Week 5, Lecture 1 · LangoBee to \$10K MRR

Summer 2026 · Operating a Solo Language App from Zero Revenue

What we'll cover

- The 174-signup number and what it actually proves
- Why founders wait for organic traction instead of going to get it
- The Collison installation: what concierge onboarding means in practice
- LangoBee's gap between recruiting and actually onboarding users
- What a real concierge session looks like for a language app
- Why unscalable moves compound beyond the first user

The only proven channel

174 signups from one channel

LangoBee has 174 direct-attributed signups as of June 2026. Every single one came from manual Discord recruiting: the founder posted in language-learning servers, replied to threads, and asked people directly.

No paid ads. No SEO. No viral loop.

What that proves:

- There is a real ICP (intermediate learners who want real native content)
- The value proposition is legible enough to convert a cold ask
- One human doing manual outreach can produce three figures of signups

What it does not prove: that any of them stayed. That is a separate problem.

(Primary data, June 2026)

The gap behind the headline number

174 signups. 50 real humans. 4 WAU. \$0 MRR.

The conversion from signup to active user is roughly 30%. The conversion from active user to returning user is low: May cohort returned at 24%.

Median activated user: 1 active day, about 2 minutes of total session time.

The channel is working. The onboarding is not.

These are two distinct problems. Conflating them is the most common mistake at this stage.

(Primary data, June 2026)

Why founders wait instead of recruit

The passive-traction fallacy: "if we build it well enough, people will find it."

Three forms it takes:

- **SEO first.** Publishing content before you know what the product does for real users.
- **The App Store listing.** Polishing metadata before fixing day-1 experience.
- **Waiting for word-of-mouth.** Referral is a retention output, not an acquisition input. You cannot manufacture it before you have stickiness.

Manual recruiting feels unscalable. That is the point. The signal you get from 20 conversations you had yourself is worth more than 2,000 signups you cannot call.

(Graham, 2013)

Manual recruiting is a skill, not a phase

Founders treat manual recruiting as something to graduate out of. The best ones never do, they just get faster at it.

What you learn by recruiting manually that you cannot learn any other way:

- Where people are actually congregating around this problem
- What language gets someone to say yes versus scroll past
- Which users are curious versus which users have real urgency

Each of those is a product and growth insight. The recruiting is not overhead: it is primary research.

The Collison installation

What concierge onboarding actually means

Graham describes how Patrick and John Collison recruited early Stripe users. When someone agreed to try Stripe, the Collisons did not send a welcome email or a Loom. They sat down with the user and walked them through the integration in real time.

Graham calls this the "Collison installation."

The key elements:

- You are physically (or virtually) present with the user
- You watch every moment of friction without intervening too fast
- You complete the setup with them so they reach the value, not just the account creation screen

This is the template. Apply it literally before you abstract it.

(Graham, 2013)

The real quote

The most common unscalable thing founders have to do at the start is recruit users manually. It's better to make a few users love you than a lot ambivalent. (Paraphrased)

Paul Graham (2013)

"Do Things That Don't Scale," paulgraham.com/ds.html

LangoBee's gap: recruits handed a debugging task

What actually happened with the 174 signups:

- User lands, sees a reader or a shorts feed
- No context for what the word-status system is or why it matters
- No first task that produces a clear win
- Top product action: `word_lookup_opened` (5,225 events in 30 days)

They were handed a product and told to figure it out. That is not onboarding. That is QA.

The founding concierge session was implicit: the founder knew what the product was for. The user did not. That context was never transferred.

(Primary data, June 2026)

What a concierge session looks like for LangoBee

A 15-minute Zoom with a new signup, before they touch the product alone:

1. Ask: what language, how long studying, what content do they usually consume
2. Open the app together, pick one piece of content that matches their answer
3. Read or watch the first 90 seconds together, out loud
4. When they tap a word, explain the status system and what "learning" means
5. End with: "come back tomorrow, find one new thing to tap"

The goal is not to demo features. The goal is to produce one moment where the product does something useful for this specific person.

That moment is the activation event. Without it, you have a signup, not a user.

Why unscalable moves compound

Manual onboarding feels like a cost. It is actually an investment in three things at once:

- **Product knowledge.** Every concierge session shows you exactly where the product fails. You cannot learn this from analytics alone.
- **Retention.** Users who were walked through setup return at higher rates. The first win is sticky.
- **Culture.** The habits you build in the first 50 users shape what kind of product you build next. High-touch early means high-care always.

You stop doing concierge onboarding when it breaks: when you have more signups per day than hours to run sessions. You are not there yet.

(Graham, 2013)

Take-aways

1. 174 manual-recruited signups prove the channel. 4 WAU proves the onboarding is broken.
Fix the second problem before scaling the first.
2. Manual recruiting is research, not a temporary embarrassment. The conversations teach you things analytics cannot.
3. Concierge onboarding means being present with the user until they reach real value, not just until they complete account setup.
4. LangoBee's gap: users were handed a product without context. The missing piece is a first session that produces one concrete win.
5. Unscalable moves compound: they fix the product, raise retention, and build the culture of care that survives when you do eventually scale.

What's next

- **Lecture 2 (this week):** Reading tiny cohorts: what $n=12$ can and cannot tell you, Mom Test rules, segmenting stickiness by content type
- **Section this week:** Run one concierge session with a new or lapsed user. Take notes. Post what broke.
- **HW5 (due end of week):** Record your concierge session notes and your updated D1 return rate after at least one onboarded user
- **Reading:** Week 5 at </c/langobee-10k-mrr-26su/readings/wk05>